

TO CARRY A WEIGHT Rashtriya Rifles soldiers return from the site of a gunfight with militants in Kashmir's Budgam district

of the improved security situation in the valley is being attributed to the efficiency of the Rashtriya Rifles (RR), the counter-insurgency force that serves in Jammu and Kashmir. Now, military planners are focusing on changing the deployment pattern of security forces in the valley. With the Prime Minister's Office (PMO) closely monitoring the security situation in Kashmir valley after the revocation of Article 370 in August 2019 and having a high stake in ushering in peace and stability, efforts are on to scale down the presence of the RR in Kashmir. A valley bristling with men in combat uniforms, guns at the ready, doesn't reflect the gradual return to paradisical tranquility, the Centre believes.

There is another reason to pare down the RR—with India assuming presidency of the G20 from December, the Centre is keen to hold its meetings in Jammu and Kashmir, and discussions to minimise the presence of men in uniform have gathered pace in closed-door meetings.

Recently in Parliament, Nityanand Rai, the Union minister of state for home affairs, corroborated the improved situation in Kashmir with figures. The number of terrorist attacks fell from 417 in 2018 to 229 in 2021, he said—a drop of 38 per cent. While 339 infiltration attempts were made in 2018, only five such attempts have occurred so far this year. Though the terror network in the Kashmir valley is still to be extirpated, it has been dealt a severe blow, observers feel. Moreover, security forces have kept up the pressure on terrorist groups by taking out their top leadership. Except for the February 2019 suicide attack on the CRPF convoy at Lethpora in Pulwama, terrorists have been reduced to attacking soft targets like unarmed migrant workers and members of the Kashmiri Pandit community. Dilbag Singh, the director-general of police, J&K, has said that terrorism in J&K was on 'crutches' and those remaining would soon be arrested or killed.

Lt Gen. Anil Ahuja (retd), who has commanded an RR sector in J&K, says that internal threats have been brought down, not least by the enhanced capacity of the state police and CAPFs (central armed police forces). He believes that reducing the visibility of the military contributes to the perception of a return to normality. "People want to see less of military convoys, road opening parties and quick reaction teams. This needs to be addressed without weakening operational capability to combat terrorists—a tightrope balance," he says. Charu Sinha, IG Kashmir, CRPF, says the paramilitary force is as well-trained and equipped with the latest weaponry as any security force. "The situation has improved manifold," she says. "Kashmiris are able to enjoy the stability missing earlier."

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Formed in 1990, when a spiralling insurgency had run paramilitary and police forces ragged, the Rashtriya Rifles is the world's largest counter-insurgency force, with around 70,000 personnel deputed from the army's various units. Decorated with numerous gallantry awards, the Rashtriya Rifles claims to have neutralised over 16,500 terrorists, including 9,000 killed, 6,800 apprehended and 1,200 surrendered. Along with better trained and equipped paramilitary and police forces, the army's 'rightsizing' plans also form the rationale to reduce the size of the RR.

Anyway, the Indian Army, responsible for guarding the Line of Control with Pakistan, has three independent corps—the Srinagar-based 15 Corps, the Udhampur-based 16 Corps and the Leh-based 14 Corps (the Drass and Kargil sectors)—totalling around 150,000 personnel in Kashmir.

RR was the brainchild of the then army chief General B.C. Joshi. Its 65 battalions are divided into five counter-insurgency headquarters—Romeo Force in Rajouri and Poonch, Delta Force in Doda, Victor Force for